in their stead, marking each location with the utmost care and accuracy. We mightn't be so lucky the second time around.

The post at Villamkulam was in an abandoned farmhouse. The roofs of the buildings had long gone and had been replaced by thatched roofs made of coconut fronds. This was fine to keep the sun out but leaked at many places whenever it rained, which was most of the time. At some time in the past, the area astride the road had been cleared for about 50 m on each side by the SLA. Mature teak trees had been brought down and the undergrowth cut so that no one could fire from close range on the convoys plying on the road. Logs from these trees had been placed around the post to form a defensive perimeter. As at the 4th Mile Post, all the old mines were retrieved, this time without any gut-wrenching incidents and replaced with new ones, especially towards the jungle side. Sentry posts were established all around and manned 24x7 by light machine guns (LMG). On the roof of the farmhouse was a water tank, over which the medium machine gun (MMG) was placed, covering the approaches from the jungle and also serving as the observation post. It was all very rudimentary and would not have held up against a sustained attack.

From these two locations, we used to send out the ROPs whenever ordered, which was about twice a week. From Villamkulam, one party used to go towards the Company HQ and marry up with the party that had come from that side. The other would go further West, up to the SLA Bn HQ and marry up with the party of (**) GR[3], which would have come from even further West over the Monkey Bridge, an old iron structure. Each and every move of ours was under the observation of the locals who served as the eyes and ears for the LTTE. We could not allow ourselves to fall into any set pattern that could be exploited. Unfortunately, our neighbouring unit was not

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